Despite this resistance and my disappointment over not doing more, we made progress I'm proud of: In 1980, federal expenditures were growing at an annual rate of more than fourteen percent; by 1987, the rate of growth was down to one percent, and if you factor in inflation, there was a net decrease in spending that year, the first since 1973.

I hope history will look back on the eighties not only as a period of economic recovery and a time when we put the brakes on the growth of government, but as a time of fundamental change for our economy and a resurgence of the American spirit of generosity that touched off an unprecedented outpouring of good deeds. While growing up in Dixon, I came to the conclusion when I was still fairly young that when it came to solving a community's problems, no one was better at it than ordinary people. Whether it was my mother bringing a meal to a family that was down on its luck, my dad canvassing the county in search of work for the jobless, or a group of neighbors getting together to help rebuild a farmer's barn lost in a fire, I witnessed how people helping one another could be a far more effective means of solving a community's problems than government giveaway programs. With that in mind, I created the White House Office of Private Sector Initiatives. Under the direction of Fred Ryan, a Los Angeles attorney, its task was to revitalize the great American spirit of neighbor helping neighbor. Through its efforts, countless Americans joined volunteer programs, and private charitable giving in America more than doubled between 1980 and 1988. The total giving in 1988 was $103.87 billion, compared with $48.73 billion in 1980—a 101.2-percent increase.

The economic crisis of the early 1980s brought hard times for many Americans. I don't undervalue for a moment the suffering they experienced as we fought together to pull the nation out of its worst economic crisis in half a century. For those who lost their farms or businesses or saw their jobs